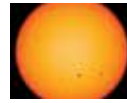


In a galaxy far, far away...

Astronomers have detected signs of water in the atmosphere of a planet that is 179 light-years away. <https://digit.in/dec18-68-1>



Sun's sibling found!

Astronomers have discovered one of the Sun's lost siblings born from the very same Solar Nebula a billion years ago. <https://digit.in/dec18-68-2>

Languages and colour perception

A new study indicates that native language might play a role in your perception of shapes in certain colours

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uite often, in everyday life, we encounter situations where the language of our choice falls short of

being able to explain something that we experience or perceive. There might be a certain word in your native language that doesn't have an equivalent counterpart in another person's native language. The ability of language to affect your perception of the world, or your thoughts, is broadly known as linguistic relativity. A new study could possibly have proven an inseparable link between the native language of an individual and their colour perception. However, this topic merits a little background first.

THE SAPIR-WHORF HYPOTHESIS

Before we begin, we would like to put in a disclaimer that Edward Sapir and his student Benjamin Lee Whorf never officially co-authored any piece of work. Some of their work even goes against what the namesake hypothesis stands for today. The name 'Sapir-Whorf' hypothesis is considered a misnomer by many linguists for that reason. With that aside, let's try to understand what this hypothesis pro-

poses. There is a strong version and a weak version of the hypothesis. The strong version is that languages determine thought, and the weak version is that languages influence thought. Essentially, the strong version implies that if the word does not exist in your language, you cannot think it. The hypothesis emerged as a consequence of studies into how languages influence human behavior. The strong version of the hypothesis, is known as "linguistic determinism", and is now universally



Edward Sapir

considered to be false. The weak version, is called "linguistic relativity".

The idea of linguistic relativity isn't new. From philosophers like Plato to Immanuel Kant, the connection between language and an individual's perception of the world has been discussed and debated throughout history. From the 1960s through the 1980s, the strong version of the hypothesis was abandoned for universalism, with proponents like Chomsky, where the commonly accepted view was that all languages held a common base structure, caused same cognitive processes in the human brain and were only different at the surface level. However, later work by George Lakoff renewed interest in Whorfianism.

The simple explanation for linguistic relativity is how Eskimos are said to have 50 words for snow, which has long been used to demonstrate linguistic relativity. A study by Princeton researchers showed that the number is actually closer to 15. Even then, Eskimos can think about snow as fallen, crusty, curved and fresh, while most people around the world would just call snow, snow, and not differentiate between the various types. New research into the topic investigates a particular aspect of languages – the words we have for colours.

NEW FINDINGS

In a recent paper, Martin Maier and Rasha Abdel Rahman at the Humboldt University of Berlin chose to analyse the impact of affecting visual processing at an early stage. The objective of this research was to determine whether someone is able to see a